The Effects of Parental Emotional Neglect in Childhood on Neurodevelopment

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Contents

Abstract..... 3

Introduction.....3

Chapter 1. Factors Contributing to Emotional Neglect..... 5

Chapter 2. The Effects of Emotional Neglect on Neurodevelopment.....9

Chapter 3. Changes in Social Behavior in Adulthood..... 14

Conclusion.....19

Bibliography:.....21

Abstract

This paper aimed to analyze the effects of parental emotional neglect in childhood on neurodevelopment and to highlight the importance and relevance of this issue. It reviewed the scientific literature on this topic, which provided a detailed analysis of the effects of neglect on emotion regulation and the development of social behavior, as well as on mental health and the capacity for social integration in adulthood.

The studies reviewed demonstrated that emotional neglect significantly alters the functioning of the amygdala, prefrontal cortex, and ventral striatum, increasing the risk of mental disorders. These neurobiological changes are associated with the risk of developing emotional dysregulation, anxiety, depression, and personality disorders. The paper also examines social factors, including poverty, parental mental disorders, and labor migration, as contributing factors to neglect.

The interdisciplinary analysis of this topic draws on psychological, neuroscientific, and social research and highlights the need to develop preventive and therapeutic mechanisms that can mitigate the long-term effects of emotional neglect and promote children's well-being.

Introduction

Emotional neglect is commonly defined as a lack of attention to a child's emotional needs by a parent or parental figure. Compared with physical and emotional abuse, emotional abuse and neglect receive relatively little attention from both the public and researchers. One reason for this is that emotional neglect often causes no visible physical injuries. Furthermore, substantial cultural differences exist in what is considered emotional neglect. For example, the neglect of girls is an accepted phenomenon in some Asian countries (Kumari, 2020).

Children from families of any sociocultural background may experience emotional neglect. However, sexual minority individuals are at particular risk because of social rejection, as are children facing severe economic hardship, such as internally displaced adolescents, who may experience emotional neglect from both their families and society. Despite cultural and geographical differences, the long-term consequences of emotional neglect include feelings of hopelessness, low self-esteem, disruptions to neurobiological stress-response systems, structural and functional brain deficits, and an increased risk of developing mental disorders. These problems include depression, anxiety, eating disorders, suicidal thoughts, psychosis, and personality disorders. Such difficulties often begin in childhood and persist into adulthood, frequently extending into old age (Kumari, 2020).

Although identifying and measuring emotional abuse presents challenges, meta-analyses of the global prevalence of childhood abuse clearly show that a substantial proportion of adults,

approximately 36%, reported having experienced emotional neglect. This figure considerably exceeds the rates of physical abuse (18%), sexual abuse (8–18%), and physical neglect (16%) (Kumari, 2020).

Among the many long-term consequences of emotional neglect discussed in subsequent sections of this paper, one of the most significant is codependency, which severely impairs individuals' quality of life. People in this state become so focused on the needs of others that they lose their own sense of identity. Consequently, they must cope with feelings such as fear of losing a loved one and being left alone, jealousy, and guilt. This leads to various mental health problems, primarily depression and anxiety. Such individuals often suppress their feelings and resort to harmful coping strategies, including excessive exercise and work, gambling, drug use, and many others (Kaya et al., 2024).

Emotional trauma experienced in childhood significantly affects an individual's self-esteem and personality development. Research shows that emotional abuse and neglect are associated with low self-esteem, difficulty accepting oneself, and negative emotions such as shame, anger, and guilt, which intensify further in adulthood and affect relationships (Kaya et al., 2024).

During childhood, parents are the primary source of emotional support. When parents are neglectful, children learn that achieving closeness requires fully meeting another person's demands. This behavioral pattern persists into adulthood, leading individuals to care excessively for another person while sacrificing their own needs (Kaya et al., 2024).

Accordingly, emotional neglect experienced in childhood significantly restricts an individual's ability to establish meaningful and lasting social connections in adulthood. Difficulties with emotion regulation, low self-esteem, and a persistent expectation of rejection prevent individuals from establishing relationships based on trust, mutual respect, and equal emotional involvement (Kaya et al., 2024).

Emotional neglect is a form of psychological abuse that often goes unnoticed by both society and professionals, yet leaves a profound mark on the individual. The consequences described above represent only a small part of the overall problem. Therefore, a thorough investigation of this issue is important both for raising awareness and for developing new therapeutic strategies. This would undoubtedly improve the quality of life of many people.

Chapter 1. Factors Contributing to Emotional Neglect

Research confirms an association between parental mental disorders and child abuse, with different psychiatric conditions affecting child development in different ways. The nature and extent of these effects depend on numerous factors, including the severity, chronicity, and type of the parent's mental disorder, as well as the individual, family, and community context. Mood

and personality disorders can be particularly harmful within the family environment. However, some psychiatric disorders, such as personality or psychotic disorders, are more difficult to manage than others, particularly when symptoms are severe, such as a risk of suicide or psychotic behavior. Effective intervention for parents with mental health problems is therefore essential both to alleviate their psychological distress and to reduce the risk of abuse among children and adolescents.

Psychotherapy, particularly Emotion-Focused Therapy (EFT), can play a substantial role in helping parents and families address emotional and interpersonal problems that increase the risk of child abuse (Lopes et al., 2021).

Children living with family members who have mental disorders face a considerably higher risk of developing mental health problems, which is associated with parental psychiatric symptoms or clinical deterioration. These risks may reflect a general vulnerability involving both genetic and environmental factors, such as an impaired caregiver–child relationship (Lopes et al., 2021).

A child's risk of developing a mental disorder depends on the type and severity of the parent's disorder, the age at symptom onset, and the parent's current condition. All of these factors significantly affect parenting abilities, caregiving, and interactions with the child. In this context, minors often assume inappropriate responsibilities that interfere with their academic activities. Researchers note that, in Canada, one in ten children under the age of 12 lives with a parent who has a psychiatric disorder (Lopes et al., 2021).

A study of adolescents whose parents were receiving care at a psychiatric clinic identified several areas adversely affected by parental mental health: interpersonal relationships, a tendency toward isolation, and a lack of social support; mental health, including anxiety, low self-esteem, and fear of developing the same illness; adverse economic consequences; limited educational opportunities; and being forced to assume an adult role (Lopes et al., 2021).

Slominski concludes that adults whose mothers have a history of mental health problems are more likely to develop mental disorders, experience anxiety, avoid intimate relationships, and fail to attain high levels of academic and professional achievement. Maternal mental health problems are also associated with inconsistent parenting and conflictual family dynamics. An Australian study involving 522 participants shows that parental depression affects externalizing disorders in adolescents. The study further confirmed an increased risk of mental illness among adolescents whose parents include one with a mental disorder and another with an addiction (Lopes et al., 2021).

Parental mental illness can affect a child's personal, family, and social development in multiple ways from childhood through adulthood. Numerous studies using different methodologies have identified parental mental health as a significant risk factor for child abuse (Lopes et al., 2021).

Symptoms such as impaired emotion regulation, avoidance, anhedonia, restricted emotional expression, sleep disturbances, difficulty concentrating, and irritability interfere with parental

functioning and lead to child neglect. These symptoms are frequently observed in bipolar disorder, depression, anxiety, schizophrenia, and posttraumatic stress disorder (PTSD). At the same time, no particular type of psychiatric disorder was found to predominate among abusive parents. In their study, mothers exhibited mood disorders (72%), anxiety disorders (in 43%, PTSD was associated with domestic and sexual violence), and suicide attempts (Lopes et al., 2021).

In one study, adult children of mothers with psychotic disorders were interviewed and described childhood experiences of abuse, neglect, and, in one case, sexual abuse. It was also noted that the psychotic condition impaired the mother's perception of reality and, consequently, her ability to respond to the child's needs. If a parent receives appropriate treatment and their symptoms are controlled, the risk of abuse is unlikely to increase. Parents with psychiatric disorders who are undergoing treatment pose a lower risk of child abuse (Lopes et al., 2021).

Drug use or alcohol misuse significantly impairs parents' caregiving abilities and is closely associated with physical abuse and neglect. The risk of child abuse and neglect is even higher when a mental disorder co-occurs with personality disorders. Furthermore, drug and alcohol misuse frequently co-occurs with poverty, domestic violence, a criminal environment, and social isolation (Lopes et al., 2021).

When discussing the causes of neglect, it is important to consider contemporary trends, including the influence of social media. Physical and emotional neglect in early childhood disrupts the perception, processing, and expression of emotions, which is particularly common when a parent's attention is directed toward a smartphone rather than the child. The ways in which parents use digital devices to soothe or relax young children are also harmful. During middle childhood, from ages 5 to 12, children increasingly compare themselves not only with their peers but also with idealized figures online, where "there is always someone who is better at something, more talented, or more attractive." During adolescence, when relationships become particularly important, the internet offers both opportunities and risks. The authors frequently cite studies showing that "the amount and quality of time spent online are directly associated with the risk of depressive and anxiety symptoms, sleep disturbances, and media dependence." Thus, excessive social media use leads parents to devote less time and attention to their children, while simultaneously becoming a means of escape for children, ultimately lowering their self-esteem and increasing anxiety and depression (Maternowska, 2025).

Research shows that parents' disregard for children's emotional signals, often arising from smartphone use, is one of the most significant sources of emotional neglect. This phenomenon is termed the "*right thumb mentality*," which describes a behavioral pattern in which individuals, particularly parents, become absorbed in moving their thumbs across device screens—switching, clicking, and typing messages—making it difficult to maintain a genuine, emotionally responsive connection with their child. In such an environment, parents often fail to

meet children's emotional needs at their particular developmental stage, leading to difficulties with emotion regulation, feelings of inadequacy, and an impaired sense of identity (Maternowska, 2025).

Furthermore, children's emotional development depends not only on verbal communication but also, to a large extent, on contact, physical closeness, and emotional responsiveness. When a parent's attention is focused on a device, these forms of emotional expression diminish, significantly affecting the child's brain development, particularly the processes involved in emotional perception and relationship formation (Maternowska, 2025).

Each year, child protection services in Canada investigate more than 230,000 cases of suspected child maltreatment. In approximately 85% of these investigations, the primary concern is the child's well-being in relation to difficulties arising from poverty and social conditions, often without an immediate physical threat. These cases are collectively categorized as "neglect," which encompasses a parent's or caregiver's failure to fulfill their responsibilities toward a child's physical, emotional, or developmental needs.

Research indicates that families' involvement with the child protection system because of neglect is often accompanied by multiple social and psychological problems, including inadequate material resources and poverty, parental physical or mental health problems, drug or alcohol dependence, and domestic violence or family conflict (Esposito et al., 2021).

Although such difficulties are part of everyday life for many families, the availability of community support often helps reduce the risks. For families without such support, however, these problems frequently develop into crises requiring state intervention. In Canada, for example, interventions focused on child safety generally fall exclusively within the mandate of the child protection system and are governed by minimum standards established by law. Consequently, the system places less emphasis on preventive or supportive interventions (Esposito et al., 2021).

The legal definition of neglect varies across provinces and territories. Under Quebec's Youth Protection Act, for example, neglect is defined as a situation in which a parent or legally responsible person fails to meet a child's basic needs. Since 2007, this definition has included the concept of "risk of neglect," which takes into account chronic circumstances in which parents are unable to overcome their difficulties, potentially producing long-term psychosocial and cognitive effects on the child. Chronicity refers to persistent, systemic difficulties that a family cannot manage and that reduce parents' ability to provide adequate care (Esposito et al., 2021).

There is a significant association between poverty and emotional neglect. Material circumstances strongly influence parents' behavior toward their children and their ability to fulfill their responsibilities adequately. This may be explained by the fact that parents who lack sufficient material resources to meet their child's needs, such as money, food, and clothing, are less able to devote emotional resources and energy to the child, ultimately leading to neglect.

This does not occur because parents do not love their children enough, but because their financial circumstances prevent them from fulfilling their parental responsibilities (Esposito et al., 2021).

Chapter 2. The Effects of Emotional Neglect on Neurodevelopment

Emotional neglect has particularly severe effects on the development of the brain and its functions. Research by Bruce Perry and Ronnie Pollard provides important insights into this issue. Two types of neglect are distinguished: global and chaotic. Global neglect refers to a condition in which a child experiences sensory deprivation in more than one domain, such as substantial deficits in linguistic stimulation, touch, and social interaction. These conditions threaten fundamental developmental processes by limiting the diversity of sensory and emotional experiences available to the child (Perry & Pollard, 1997).

The authors describe chaotic neglect as a comparatively more common form. It is characterized by inconsistent, unstable, or absent physical, emotional, social, or cognitive support. Global neglect means that a child is entirely deprived of essential care and stimulation. In cases of chaotic neglect, children may occasionally receive attention, but this care is unstable, sporadic, and often changes unexpectedly. Such an inconsistent environment creates uncertainty and persistent psychoemotional stress for the child (Perry & Pollard, 1997).

Emotions emerge from the earliest stages of life and play an important role in an individual's social and neurobiological development. An emotional response comprises three components: neurological, psychological, and behavioral. Emotional processing and regulation occur primarily through the limbic system, which is responsible for perceiving and interpreting emotion-eliciting stimuli and initiating an appropriate response (Perry & Pollard, 1997).

Research demonstrates that emotional responses in newborns may occur without cognitive mediation. For example, even infants with hydranencephaly exhibit emotional responses such as rejecting unpleasant tastes and preferring sweet ones, suggesting that the basic mechanisms of emotion are instinctive and operate at a fundamental level. As children grow older, the causes of emotional experiences become more abstract and cognitively mediated. Whereas an infant's disgust may be elicited solely by a bitter taste, an older child may express a similar feeling in a moral or ideological context. Emotional development is not determined solely by biological processes; it is closely related to the social environment and the quality of care. This feedback mechanism helps children understand how and when to express particular emotions. Neglect disrupts this natural cycle, often leading to difficulties with emotion regulation, impulsivity, or, conversely, emotional isolation (Perry & Pollard, 1997).

The authors emphasize the importance of the timing of neglect, since the human brain undergoes rapid growth during the first years of life and is particularly vulnerable at this stage to

environments that lack structured experiences. Children who had experienced prolonged parental neglect exhibited altered brain growth. Their brains were considerably smaller than those of children raised in a normal environment (Perry & Pollard, 1997).

In some cases, emotional neglect may impair children's motor functions; for example, some children begin smiling later. Parents' emotional states and parenting styles influence the development of children's adaptive abilities. Consequently, the emotional unavailability of a parent, who serves as a source of emotional support and a central figure in the child's life, is also reflected in the child's behavior and cognitive processes (Perry & Pollard, 1997).

Several decades ago, genetic inheritance was thought to determine much of a child's life. It is now recognized, however, that heredity and the environment interact to influence the individual; in other words, nature and nurture are closely interconnected. In this respect, the child's environment, which is largely created by the parent, also affects biological processes, ultimately influencing development and health positively or negatively throughout life. This influence is particularly important during the first months and years of life, when the brain is still in the early stages of development and is therefore more plastic, meaning that it can readily adapt to environmental influences. At the same time, it is more vulnerable to potentially adverse environmental factors, particularly chronic and toxic stress (De-Bofarull et al., 2018).

Recent research has identified the effects of emotional neglect on amygdala functioning. A study found pronounced hyperactivation of the right amygdala in individuals who had experienced emotional abuse or neglect. These findings underscore the central role of the amygdala, which is affected by childhood abuse, resulting in heightened emotional responses and dysregulation of emotion-related processes. Recent studies show that alterations in brain development play an important role in the problems arising from emotional abuse, particularly in regions responsible for emotional processing: the amygdala, prefrontal cortex, and hippocampus. A better understanding of the interaction between the amygdala and prefrontal cortex is essential for accurately determining the effects of abuse on children (Kou & Yao, 2025).

These findings support the view that emotional neglect may cause neurobiological disturbances, including difficulties with emotion regulation and disrupted emotional responses, which may underlie more serious mental health problems such as anxiety and depression (Kou & Yao, 2025).

Childhood abuse, including emotional neglect, is associated with structural changes in the brain. In general, children who experienced abuse and subsequently developed posttraumatic stress disorder (PTSD) exhibit reduced cerebral volume and lower overall gray matter volume. Numerous studies also show reductions in cortical volume or thickness following abuse, particularly in prefrontal regions associated with emotion regulation (Jedd et al., 2016).

Emotional trauma may trigger a cascade of neurobiological events with potentially lasting consequences. Early abuse and neglect disrupt the child's still-developing neurobiological system, reduce the ability to cope with stressful events, and consequently lead to difficulties with emotion regulation. Children who have experienced physical or emotional abuse tend to direct excessive attention toward negative stimuli (Giotakos, 2020).

The "scar hypothesis" and theories of behavioral sensitization or electrophysiological "kindling" suggest that emotional trauma may leave lasting changes in the brain that persist even after depression remits and increase the risk of new episodes, even under conditions of moderate psychosocial stress (Giotakos, 2020).

Adverse social experiences in early childhood, such as emotional abuse, may affect the structure and function of the prefrontal cortex. Overwhelming or repeated stress may influence brain structure and functioning even in the absence of a PTSD diagnosis. Research shows that these conditions increase synapse formation and dendritic growth in the amygdala, the brain region responsible for emotional responses. At the same time, dendritic atrophy is observed in the hippocampus, which is involved in memory and emotion regulation, indicating impaired functioning. As a result, individuals may develop anxiety responses, particularly to specific triggers, such as a fear of open spaces (agoraphobia) (Giotakos, 2020).

There is also a significant association between damage to the ventral striatum and depressive symptoms. The ventral striatum is a brain region involved in motivation, the experience of reward, and the regulation of emotions and behavior. It also facilitates the learning and reinforcement of new habits and behaviors. Parental emotional neglect is one of the main factors contributing to its dysfunction, and damage to this brain region underlies the emergence and worsening of depressive symptoms. A lack of emotional connection, for which the parent bears responsibility, may lead to feelings of worthlessness in the child (Hanson et al., 2015).

According to the study, reduced ventral striatal activity during development may lead to abnormal corticostriatal connectivity associated with severe depressive symptoms. Reduced activity in this brain region may contribute to reward avoidance and reduced social engagement. These factors may be exacerbated in stressful situations and are correlated with the severe depression described above (Hanson et al., 2015).

It is now established that childhood trauma has enduring and devastating consequences. Over the past two decades, research has not only identified these effects in relation to health and disease but has also begun to elucidate the mechanisms underlying the association between childhood trauma and medical outcomes, including psychiatric outcomes (Lippard & Nemeroff, 2020).

Research is gradually clarifying how childhood trauma affects the risk and course of disease. It increases the likelihood of mental health conditions such as mood and anxiety disorders, posttraumatic stress disorder (PTSD), antisocial and borderline personality disorders, and alcohol and substance use disorders (A/SUDs). Childhood trauma is often associated with earlier illness onset, more severe symptoms, and a poorer response to pharmacological and psychotherapeutic treatment (Lippard & Nemeroff, 2020).

In addition to psychological problems, severe adverse experiences in early life also increase the risk of several serious physical diseases. These include coronary artery disease and myocardial infarction, cerebrovascular disease and stroke, type II diabetes mellitus, asthma, and certain types of cancer (Lippard & Nemeroff, 2020).

Numerous studies have shown that experiences of emotional rejection in childhood are more prevalent among patients with depression and bipolar disorder. More specifically, one recent meta-analysis found that 46% of people with depression had experienced childhood abuse or neglect. Patients with bipolar disorder also report similarly high rates, often reaching 57% (Lippard & Nemeroff, 2020).

Research also indicates that emotional abuse and neglect during childhood are among the most robust factors associated with the development of borderline personality disorder (BPD) symptoms. Experiences of physical and sexual abuse are also associated with this disorder, although the associations were weaker. Childhood neglect was significantly associated with BPD, whereas emotional abuse in this group was associated with other types of personality disorders (Brotto et al., 2024).

As a result of trauma experienced in early childhood, children may fail to develop the skills needed to understand, regulate, or appropriately express their emotions. This, in turn, underlies the impulsivity and emotional dysregulation associated with BPD. This disorder, which is 13 times more common among individuals who have experienced childhood trauma, is characterized by various symptoms. These include fear of abandonment, unstable relationships, an unstable self-image, impulsivity, suicidal or self-injurious behavior, emotional instability, intense anger, lack of trust, and paranoid ideation or dissociation. These symptoms further impair the ability to regulate emotions and manage stress, potentially causing irreversible harm to the individual (Brotto et al., 2024).

Disordered eating behaviors often adversely affect health. Such behaviors may contribute to obesity, diabetes, cardiovascular disease, and many other conditions. Disordered eating behaviors contribute to the development of eating and personality disorders, reduced self-esteem, and improved quality of life. A toxic home environment, lack of discipline, physical abuse, and insufficient parental attention are associated with inadequate development of emotion regulation skills in children, encouraging the adoption of dysfunctional strategies for

coping with emotions. For example, young people who tend toward emotional isolation often increase their food intake uncontrollably. The study confirmed that childhood trauma is associated with uncontrolled and emotional eating, characterized by higher levels of intrusive thoughts and lower levels of cognitive reappraisal (Dawson et al., 2022).

Chapter 3. Changes in Social Behavior in Adulthood

An important consideration when discussing neglect is how traumatic experiences affect a child's social behavior. Individual behavior results from complex, interdependent processes involving both personal characteristics and life experiences. It is therefore difficult to determine how social behavior changes, since it is necessary to consider the duration of parental neglect, the child's age, and the type of neglect. In particular, physical, sexual, and emotional abuse must be distinguished, because each form has a different effect on the adolescent (Dobowitz et al., 2022).

Children and adolescents who experience neglect may not know what kind of care and attention they should receive from their parents and may therefore not consider themselves neglected, further complicating research. In the study conducted by Dobowitz and colleagues, the "late neglect" group is particularly noteworthy. This group began reporting various forms of neglect during middle adolescence. Initially, they resembled the "limited neglect" group, but later became more similar to the "chronic neglect" group. The reason for this change is unknown. An analysis of recent life events and financial circumstances revealed no differences between the groups. One important finding was that neglect was associated with impaired functioning in several domains: aggression toward a partner, psychological stress, and criminal behavior (Dobowitz et al., 2022).

Other studies show that adults who experienced neglect in childhood are economically disadvantaged. They attain lower levels of education, while women are less likely to be employed, own property, or have a bank account. Childhood neglect was associated with mental health problems in adulthood, including anxiety, depression, and risky behavior in relationships. These diverse consequences illustrate how the same risk factors may lead to entirely different outcomes. A bidirectional association between childhood neglect and relationship violence has already been established. One hypothesis is that neglect disrupts attachment to parents, which may subsequently manifest as violent behavior toward a partner because of fears concerning control or abandonment (Dobowitz et al., 2022).

Research shows a strong association between childhood trauma and psychopathology in adulthood. For example, as I noted earlier, an unhealthy relationship with a parent may make it difficult to establish healthy relationships. Neglect is also associated with behavioral disorders during adolescence, creating subsequent difficulties with education, employment, and behavioral regulation, including an increased likelihood of drug use. Neglect is associated with

antisocial behavior, and these young people are more frequently involved with criminal groups and violent acts. Neglect during adolescence has rarely been investigated, yet, despite their increasing autonomy, adolescents remain substantially dependent on their caregivers. In this context, it is particularly striking that the “late neglect” group had the highest risk of developing problems in early adulthood, even higher than that of individuals who experienced chronic neglect. Individuals exposed to chronic neglect may have learned to cope with the problem and may have been less aware of the lack of care. They may have assumed parental roles themselves, which sometimes includes protecting themselves from drug use. Sudden or later-onset neglect may have a more powerful traumatic effect (Dobowitz et al., 2022).

Childhood maltreatment is one of the most significant risk factors for impaired social functioning and mental health in adulthood. According to the biobehavioral synchrony hypothesis, the oxytocin and attachment systems play important mediating roles in the relationship between emotional neglect and social dysfunction. Emotional neglect was associated with lower plasma oxytocin levels, which are associated with greater fear and avoidance of social situations. Thus, plasma oxytocin mediates the effects of emotional neglect on social fear and avoidance of other people (Muller et al., 2019).

Social functioning can be defined as the ability to make friends, understand different people, help others, and be sensitive to their feelings and needs. This requires the ability to develop emotional closeness with others. Fear and avoidance of social situations can therefore be considered two major and widespread aspects of social dysfunction, as they interfere with social relationships and access to social support and generally reduce life satisfaction. Fear of social situations and avoidance of other people are also core criteria for social anxiety disorder. Interestingly, fear of social situations has previously been linked to early experiences of emotional abuse, including emotional neglect. Regarding the pathways through which emotional neglect may lead to impaired social functioning, theories of biobehavioral synchrony identify the oxytocin and attachment systems as the principal physiological and psychological mediators. To date, some indirect evidence supports this hypothesis. First, emotional neglect is associated with changes in the oxytocin system. Second, reduced plasma oxytocin levels have been found in individuals who experienced childhood maltreatment. Finally, animal studies suggest that fear of social situations is associated with alterations in the oxytocin system, such as reduced oxytocin levels in the central nervous system (Muller et al., 2019).

Attachment theory explains many problems associated with neglect, including changes in social behavior. One study found that neglected children often have fewer social relationships and tend to be avoidant in their social interactions. They are rarely popular among their peers and have fewer friends in the classroom than other children. However, a child may function differently across settings, such as home and school. The parent–child relationship may also lead different observers to interpret the child’s behavior differently. In some cases, teachers’ assessments are considered more objective for several reasons. Parents who themselves grew

up in abusive environments may perceive events subjectively and negatively or fail to respond sensitively and appropriately to their child's emotions. Some parents may have excessive expectations of their children or negative perceptions of them. Parental perceptions may be influenced by factors such as stress, conflict, and limited parenting skills. These considerations indicate that a comprehensive assessment of a child's emotional and behavioral functioning requires comparison across different perspectives and contexts. Numerous studies show that neglect is associated with social, emotional, and behavioral problems that often manifest as internalizing symptoms. However, an assessment conducted by only one person cannot provide a complete picture of the child's functioning and does not rule out externalizing symptoms. Factors such as the child's developmental environment, temperament, and personality characteristics must also be considered. The study aimed to determine the roles of different factors in the emergence of children's emotional and behavioral problems and to examine internalizing and externalizing symptoms in neglected children using traditional and clinical scales. For this purpose, two versions of the same questionnaire were used: one completed by the biological parent and the other by the child's teacher (Nadeau et al., 2014).

The researchers proposed the following hypotheses: 1. Neglected children would exhibit more internalizing symptoms, such as anxiety, depression, and thought problems, as well as more externalizing symptoms, such as frequent rule-breaking and aggressive behavior, than the control group. 2. They would also have higher scores on clinical scales than the control group. 3. The child's behavioral and emotional profile would differ depending on whether the assessment was made by the parent or the teacher (Nadeau et al., 2014).

The study found that neglected children did indeed exhibit more pronounced internalizing symptoms and, at the same time, significantly more externalizing symptoms. On DSM-IV-oriented scales, teachers' assessments indicated that neglected children had significantly higher scores on scales measuring conduct problems, ADHD, and posttraumatic stress. The study also revealed a marked discrepancy between parental and teacher assessments. Specifically, parents largely failed to recognize existing problems, although they did report externalizing symptoms on DSM-IV scales, such as conduct problems or hyperactivity. Teachers, by contrast, provided a more comprehensive account of both internalizing and externalizing problems (Nadeau et al., 2014).

The CDC–Kaiser studies clearly demonstrated an association between adverse childhood experiences and health problems in adulthood. However, less attention has been paid to behavioral problems caused by adverse childhood experiences during childhood itself. Evidence indicates that both internalizing problems, such as anxiety and depression, and externalizing problems, such as aggression, frequently arise following exposure to adverse experiences. For example, one study found that children who had experienced neglect were 33 times more likely

to have behavioral or learning problems. Other studies have also confirmed that trauma may be associated with increased attention and behavioral problems from the age of five (Hunt et al., 2017).

Children with behavioral problems are more likely to develop clinically significant mental and physical illnesses later in life. For example, children who experience anxiety or depression face a higher risk of chronic depression in adulthood. Children with behavioral problems may also develop health-related risks during adolescence, including impaired regulation of sexual behavior, drug use, and obesity, ultimately leading to serious and life-threatening illnesses. Examining behavioral problems during middle childhood therefore makes an important contribution to a comprehensive understanding of the effects of adverse experiences resulting from neglect (Hunt et al., 2017).

Evidence indicates that the treatment of children differs across families according to socioeconomic status. Children living in low-income families are known to be frequent victims of abuse. This may reflect a lack of financial, emotional, and social resources, which creates stress and leads parents to adopt harsher approaches. Similarly, the risk of maltreatment and adverse experiences is unevenly distributed across racial and ethnic groups: Black and Latino children often grow up in disadvantaged environments and experience higher rates of abuse (Hunt et al., 2017).

Although adolescents living in socially disadvantaged families may face a higher risk of adverse childhood experiences, the effects of these experiences across different social groups remain incompletely understood. Existing studies offer conflicting findings. For example, Schilling and colleagues report that adverse childhood experiences are sometimes more harmful to White adolescents than to their Black or Latino peers. Other studies indicate different results, reinforcing the need for more detailed and diverse research in this area (Hunt et al., 2017).

Some evidence also indicates gender differences in vulnerability to maltreatment. Certain studies suggest that the impact of neglect is greater among boys (Hunt et al., 2017).

Emotional neglect experienced during childhood may have substantial and lasting effects on an individual's social behavior and ability to form relationships. Emotional neglect often manifests as parental emotional unavailability and a lack of affection and support, disrupting the child's capacity to experience and express emotional closeness. Impairment of these abilities particularly undermines the development of secure emotional attachments to parents, peers, and future partners, constituting a significant barrier to social functioning (Mbutitia & Adeli, 2020).

Children raised in unhealthy environments often develop deficits in social skills, manifested in explosive behavior and strained, unstable relationships with both peers and adults. They struggle to develop trust, consistently expect rejection, and have substantially reduced self-esteem, increasing the risk of emotional alienation and a tendency toward social isolation.

Consequently, their social interactions are often characterized by silence, defensiveness, or withdrawal from relationships (Mbutitia & Adeli, 2020).

The study used a qualitative research method. Participants were selected using the Childhood Emotional Neglect Questionnaire (CEN), which identified individuals with high levels of childhood emotional neglect. In-depth interviews were conducted to explore participants' personal experiences. The study took place in real-life settings without prior intervention or experimental control. Its findings confirmed that emotional neglect experienced in childhood is not a temporary phenomenon; its consequences often persist into adolescence and adulthood. A tendency toward social distancing, difficulties identifying one's own emotions, and impaired development of empathy make it difficult for these children to establish functional social connections and achieve social integration. Emotional neglect should therefore be understood as a long-term risk factor that significantly restricts individuals' social abilities and impedes their personal development and integration into society (Mbutitia & Adeli, 2020).

Conclusion

Emotional neglect in childhood is a hidden yet profoundly destructive form of abuse that leaves lasting psychological, neurobiological, and social consequences throughout an individual's life. It becomes a form of trauma that continues to pose a major therapeutic challenge for professionals. Parents' disregard for emotional needs interferes with the development and maintenance of emotion regulation, social relationships, self-esteem, and personal stability. Existing research has demonstrated that emotional neglect affects structural brain development, particularly in regions such as the amygdala, prefrontal cortex, and ventral striatum, ultimately leading to stress, anxiety, depression, and personality disorders over the long term.

The consequences of emotional neglect become ingrained in the mind as insurmountable barriers and often impair an individual's capacity for social integration and functional relationships in adulthood.

Future research should devote attention to adolescents who experienced this trauma at a relatively later age and have consequently been overlooked by many researchers. This would help professionals develop appropriate strategies to support them. It is also important to examine different ethnic and gender groups in greater detail, since existing findings are generalized within the geographical areas studied. This is insufficient to provide a comprehensive picture, as different patterns may emerge across groups.

The literature and studies discussed above examine a range of issues, including the association between mental disorders and emotional neglect, its effects on personal relationships and emotion regulation, and the importance of ventral striatal functioning and its relationship with

depression. Despite this, gaps remain that offer opportunities to investigate the topic from new perspectives.

Research in this area would be particularly important in Georgia, where the country's socioeconomic circumstances are a primary reason for parental emigration, especially maternal emigration, leaving children without parental care.

Labor migrants generally migrate alone, while family members, including spouses and children, remain in the country of origin. In the literature, families physically separated by national borders are referred to as transnational families, and the phenomenon is termed transnationalism. The term "left-behind children" is often used to describe the children of migrant parents who grow up without their parents (Antia et al., 2022).

In Georgia, more than 57% of migrants are women, while almost 39% of all children are affected by migration, the highest proportion in Eastern Europe. Recent studies also indicate an increased risk of both physical and mental health problems among children affected by migration. In Georgia, the number of children with mental and behavioral disorders increased fourfold between 2013 and 2019, from 1.1 to 4.4 per 100,000 children. Although Georgia's Ministry of Health and other public health institutions state that children's health and well-being remain among their principal priorities, the needs of left-behind children are not adequately reflected in state policy (Antia et al., 2022).

The effects of parental labor migration on child development and well-being in Georgia remain insufficiently researched. The existing literature has several important limitations. One major problem is the small number of studies, which prevents reliable conclusions from being drawn on a broad scale. A second important limitation is the lack of methodological diversity. Existing studies predominantly use qualitative methods, such as focus groups and interviews. These studies are generally conducted with school personnel, limiting the development and analysis of a comprehensive picture.

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